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MASTER'S THESIS PROPOSAL

隱形帳簿：量化印尼平台經濟中的隱形楔子
The Invisible Ledger: Quantifying the Invisible Wedge in Indonesia's Platform Economy

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Abstract

This study measures the difference between the transaction value digital platforms process in Indonesia and the revenue those platforms recognize for themselves. I call that difference the invisible wedge. The absolute wedge is $W = V - R$, where V is transaction value and R is platform revenue; the Ecosystem Ratio, $E = (V - R)/R$, expresses the same boundary relative to revenue and is constructed for this study rather than adopted from prior work. Because no Indonesian platform discloses a strictly country-labelled matched pair across the study period, observations are retained under named evidence tiers rather than pooled as if equal in scope. The inventory spans seventeen candidate platform-year levels from FY2019 to FY2025. The proposal asks how large the wedge is, how it changes, and what explains those changes, then uses official statistics and Indonesia's marketplace-reporting rules to locate related activity and records beyond platform revenue.

1. Introduction

Southeast Asia's digital economy grew from US\$100 billion in gross transaction value in 2020 to US\$263 billion in 2024 (Google, Temasek and Bain 2020, 2024; reported there as gross merchandise value). Much of that activity is coordinated through digital platforms, but transaction value can be far larger than the revenue a platform recognizes for itself. Platforms record transactions, determine participant payouts, and book their own revenue. I call the difference between transaction value processed through a platform and platform-booked revenue the invisible wedge.

Suppose a platform processes 100 units of transaction value but recognizes only 10 units as revenue. The remaining 90 units are still recorded within the platform's system but do not constitute platform revenue; they may include merchant receipts, driver payouts, inventory costs, taxes paid elsewhere, and other pass-through payments. The paper measures this accounting gap without assuming that the residual is profit, taxable income, or unpaid tax. The 90-unit difference is the absolute wedge, $W = V - R$.

I measure the wedge relative to revenue with the Ecosystem Ratio, $E = (V - R)/R$. For FY2023, three selected platform cases imply a combined wedge of approximately US\$40.07 billion, about 2.9 percent of Indonesia's 2023 nominal GDP. This is a scale comparison only: the wedge is transaction value outside platform revenue, not GDP value added, participant profit, or a tax gap.

The term invisible therefore does not imply concealment. A platform may hold seller- or worker-linked transaction records even when those records do not enter routine third-party income reporting. The wedge does not measure that reporting gap. It measures the transaction–revenue boundary; the reporting question is whether records behind that activity are separately transmitted and usable outside the platform.

1.1 Research question and objectives

One question drives the proposal:

How large is the invisible wedge in Indonesia, how does it change over time, and what explains those changes?

The empirical design follows three objectives: measure the wedge longitudinally under explicit evidence tiers; explain material movements using issuer-disclosed revenue components; and connect the measured boundary to wider Indonesian activity and to seller-linked reporting

institutions. A separate 48-issuer-year module outside Indonesia is retained only as external corroboration, not as a second main sample or research question.

1.2 Contributions

First, longitudinal measurement. The evidence base expands from a one-year comparison to candidate observations spanning FY2019–FY2025, while keeping direct Indonesia-aligned, direct scope-pending, and conditional observations separate.

Second, mechanism. The thesis reconciles material transaction–revenue divergences against disclosed monetization, customer incentives, gross-versus-net recognition, and business perimeter. These are arithmetic reconciliations, not causal decompositions.

Third, economic and institutional interpretation. Evidence from BPS-Statistics Indonesia (Badan Pusat Statistik) locates wider e-commerce activity and recordkeeping beyond issuer accounts, while Indonesia's Regulation PMK 37/2025 (Peraturan Menteri Keuangan) and Directorate General of Taxes (DJP) materials show how platform-held seller and transaction records can enter reporting and withholding. The proposal does not claim a completed compliance or tax-revenue effect.

2. Literature Review and Research Gap

2.1 Platform economics and revenue recognition

Multisided-platform theory explains why a platform's revenue need not move proportionally with the transaction value it coordinates (Rochet and Tirole 2003; Caillaud and Jullien 2003; Parker and Van Alstyne 2005; Armstrong 2006; Hagiu and Wright 2015; Evans and Schmalensee 2016). Accounting further determines how much facilitated commerce becomes recognized revenue: principal–agent treatment, customer incentives, service mix, acquisitions, and reporting perimeter can move revenue without an equivalent change in underlying commerce. De Franco, Kothari and Verdi (2011) show why financial-statement comparability matters when users interpret such differences.

2.2 Informality, digital records, and third-party information

Platform participants occupy an unusual position. Their transactions can be priced, recorded, and settled through a formal intermediary while participants remain self-employed, unregistered, below filing thresholds, or outside automatic reporting. The object measured here is therefore not the shadow economy as conventionally defined (La Porta and Shleifer 2014; Ulyssea 2018; Medina and Schneider 2019). Digital records can nevertheless carry economic information even when conventional records are thin (Berg et al. 2020), and platform-mediated work leaves observable financial and administrative traces (Barrios, Hochberg and Yi 2022; Denes, Lagaras and Tsoutsoura 2025).

A central public-finance result is that third-party information can materially change compliance and enforcement (Kleven et al. 2011; Pomeranz 2015; Naritomi 2019; Kleven, Kreiner and Saez 2016; Slemrod 2019). The OECD Model Rules and the European Union's DAC7 regime provide direct precedents for using platform-held seller information in reporting. Indonesia's PMK 37/2025 applies the same broad logic through seller identification, transaction-linked reporting, and marketplace withholding.

2.3 Research gap

The literature explains why transaction value can exceed platform revenue, why accounting can move the two apart, and why third-party records matter. What remains missing is a longitudinal, source-auditable account for one market that measures the wedge, explains why it moves, and then asks where the wider activity and its records appear beyond platform revenue.

3. Theoretical Framework and Key Variables

Let V denote transaction value and R platform-recognized revenue for a matched platform scope and period. The core measures are:

$$W = V - R$$

$$E = (V - R) / R$$

$$D = g(V) - g(R)$$

W is the absolute invisible wedge; E is the Ecosystem Ratio, which is my own construction for this paper rather than a measure adopted from a prior study; and D is the annual growth divergence between transaction value and revenue. A higher E indicates more transaction value outside platform revenue per unit of platform revenue; it does not by itself imply more participant profit, taxable income, value added, non-compliance, or tax due.

Gross transaction value (GTV) is used as the proposal's common label for the value processed through a platform. Issuers use different labels—GMV or TPV among them—and those source labels and business perimeters remain recorded in the empirical files rather than being treated as economically interchangeable. Accordingly, the main longitudinal comparisons are within named series; cross-platform levels are descriptive and scope-labelled.

4. Data and Methodology

4.1 Admission rules and evidence tiers

A platform-period is eligible only when transaction value and revenue cover the same period; geography and business scope can be evaluated; units and definitions are known; derived inputs trace to source; and structural breaks or revised reporting bases are flagged. Repeated publication vintages are not counted as independent observations. Eligibility does not imply final main-sample admission.

Table 1. Evidence tiers for Indonesian platform observations. Tiers differ in how directly each series maps to Indonesia; they are never pooled into a single monetary total.

Evidence tier	Series	Retained levels	Transitions
Direct Indonesia-aligned segment	Tokopedia e-commerce	2	1
Direct issuer, scope-pending	Blibli 3P Retail; Bukalapak Group	9	7
Conditional country reconstruction	Grab Indonesia; Shopee Indonesia	6	4
All tiers, inventory diagnostic	Five series	17	12

Table 1 shows that only two of the seventeen retained levels are directly Indonesia-aligned, so sample size and evidence quality move in opposite directions. Tokopedia is the strongest

Indonesia-aligned segment but is not a literal country line. Blibli includes online travel, Bukalapak reports at Group scope with overseas operations, and Grab/Shopee require a derived or external country component. Tokopedia FY2021 and Bukalapak FY2024 are excluded because transaction and revenue periods do not match.

The 13 direct candidate periods reported in the advisor-facing eligibility census are not the same count as the 11 direct levels retained in the executed tiered inventory above. The direct-candidate longitudinal sensitivity applies its own admission rule—including a Blibli FY2020 prospectus observation—and contains 9 transitions. These counts answer different construction questions and are therefore reported separately rather than collapsed into one N.

4.2 Conditional country evidence

Grab discloses Indonesia revenue but not Indonesia transaction value. Its conditional country transaction value is therefore derived as:

$$\text{Indonesia GTV} = \text{Indonesia revenue} \times \text{Group GTV} / \text{Group revenue}$$

The construction assumes the Group monetization rate applies to Indonesia and is treated as sensitivity evidence, not direct disclosure. Shopee's Indonesia transaction value uses Momentum Works' recurring Southeast Asian e-commerce estimates because Sea Limited does not disclose an Indonesian country figure; it is labelled third-party wherever used.

5. Preliminary Evidence and Feasibility

5.1 FY2023 scale

Table 2. Indonesia-focused FY2023 cross-section, US\$ billions. V is transaction value, R platform revenue, W the wedge and E the Ecosystem Ratio. The final row sums three documented cases under mixed evidence classes and is not a national total.

Case	V	R	W	E	Evidence class
Grab Indonesia	5.381	0.605	4.776	7.895×	Derived V
Tokopedia e-commerce	16.331	0.405	15.926	39.296×	Direct pair
Shopee Indonesia	21.520	2.152	19.368	9.000×	Derived V and R
Selected platforms	43.233	3.162	40.070	12.671×	Sum, not national total

Table 2 reports the FY2023 cross-section. These cases establish the order of magnitude and feasibility of the measure. Sensitivity and leave-one-platform-out checks do not remove the large transaction–revenue gap, but they are treated as robustness material rather than the thesis's main result.

5.2 Longitudinal movement and mechanism

Table 3. Within-series annual divergence under two admission rules. Counts differ because evidence admission differs; both are reported rather than resolved into one headline.

	All-tier inventory	Direct-candidate sensitivity
Transitions	12	9
Revenue grows faster	10	6
Transaction grows faster	2	3
Opposite-sign transitions	2	3
Median absolute divergence	42.02 pp	42.94 pp

Table 3 compares the two admission rules. The summaries differ because the rules differ; neither is a filtered restatement of the other. Tokopedia FY2022–FY2023 provides the cleanest mechanism example: transaction value falls 8.90 percent while selected third-party net segment revenue rises 53.20 percent. Of the arithmetic increase in net revenue, 60.56 percent is associated with lower customer incentives and 39.44 percent with higher gross revenue. This reconciles the divergence without claiming causality.

5.3 Wider Indonesian activity and reporting

BPS reports national e-commerce transaction value rising 17.08 percent from 2023 to 2024. Over the same period, the directly reported marketplace component rises only 1.45 percent, while the non-marketplace component rises 20.57 percent; approximately 98.46 percent of the nominal increase therefore falls outside the marketplace component. These aggregates provide a wider view of e-commerce activity and are not reconciled one-for-one to issuer transaction value.

PMK 37/2025 provides the institutional bridge. The verified implementation sequence records marketplace designation on 1 July 2026, collection effective 1 August, postponement through 31 October, and scheduled implementation on 1 November 2026. The regulation is used as evidence of seller-linked reporting architecture, not as proof of prior underpayment or a completed compliance effect.

Outside Indonesia, 48 matched issuer-years across eight platform businesses show that transaction value and revenue can also diverge under other business models. This evidence remains external corroboration only; it is neither pooled with Indonesia nor treated as a representative global sample.

6. Limitations and Proposal Decisions

The proposal makes four boundaries explicit. First, $V - R$ is not participant profit, taxable income, unpaid tax, tax evasion, or missing GDP. Second, evidence tiers differ in directness and cannot be silently pooled. Third, issuer-component reconciliations are arithmetic rather than causal. Fourth, BPS and PMK evidence establish aggregate patterns and institutional design, not firm-level causal effects or completed policy outcomes.

Two sample decisions remain for the advisor / committee: whether Blibli 3P Retail and Bukalapak Group are admissible in the final longitudinal core, and whether Grab and Shopee should remain sensitivity evidence only. The proposal exposes those decisions rather than treating them as already approved.

7. Next Step

After the proposal examination the approved sample boundary will be frozen and the requested checks completed during October–November 2026, with the full manuscript rebuilt around that boundary before the final defence. Robustness, ASEAN/payment extensions, detailed source reconciliation, and the complete verification ledger remain available in the repository and advisor data package rather than occupying proposal space.

Appendix A — data sources by evidence tier

Tier	Series	Source of V	Source of R
Direct Indonesia-aligned	Tokopedia e-commerce	GoTo annual report, e-commerce segment metrics	GoTo annual report, segment note
Direct, scope-pending	Blibli 3P Retail	Global Digital Niaga prospectus and results releases	Same issuer filings
Direct, scope-pending	Bukalapak Group	Bukalapak annual and sustainability reports	Same issuer filings
Conditional reconstruction	Grab Indonesia	Derived from disclosed Indonesia revenue and the Group monetization rate (Form 20-F)	Grab Form 20-F
Conditional reconstruction	Shopee Indonesia	Momentum Works Southeast Asia e-commerce estimate (third-party)	Derived from Sea Limited Form 20-F
National statistics	BPS-Statistics Indonesia	E-Commerce Statistics 2023, 2024; BPS directorate presentation	—
Regulatory	PMK 37/2025; DJP	Ministry of Finance of the Republic of Indonesia	—

Every figure used in this proposal traces to a named file and locator in the accompanying data package.

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Primary and Institutional Sources

Data statement. Company filings, annual reports, prospectuses and results materials provide the platform data. BPS, Bank Indonesia, the Ministry of Finance and DJP publications provide the business, payment and policy evidence. The working data file records source, definition, publication date, currency and scope for every measure, so each figure can be checked against the original disclosure.

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